

15.338 Leadership & Teams Lab: Navigating and Leveraging Difference

Syllabus: Summer 2026

Course Instructor

[Nelson Repenning](mailto:nelson@mit.edu) (nelson@mit.edu)

Teaching Assistant (TA)

Arya Yadama (yadama@mit.edu)

MIT Leadership Center Executive Leadership Coaches

Joanna Brownstein, Patricia Bueno dos Santos, Eleanor Chin, Gavin Fenn-Smith, Gabriele Ganswindt, Wil Herrington, Cory Little, Meghan Mahoney, Nicki Roth, Joonki Song, Regan Stein, Ken Tebbetts, Suzanne Wilkins

Course Purpose and Rationale

Contemporary society faces several serious and interconnected challenges, including climate change, growing income inequality, and rising social and political instability. While we often look to politicians for solutions, leaders of the world's productive organizations also play a critical role in society's response to these challenges. MIT, MIT Sloan, and the MIT Sloan Fellows MBA program exist largely to equip leaders both to address these complex problems and to play a central role in resolving them.

Against this backdrop, Leadership and Teams Lab is designed to help you cultivate the capacities needed to navigate the major challenges that will inevitably confront the organizations you lead. The course builds on three core ideas.

- Combining conflicting ideas and perspectives is a critical component of innovation and, therefore, of developing solutions to complex challenges.
- Individuals, teams, and organizations are often conflict averse, even when conflict is necessary for progress.
- Since the very differences that make innovation possible also tend to trigger defensiveness and reactivity, effective leadership requires greater self-awareness to recognize those responses, regulate them, and engage more reflectively.

The course's primary objective is to make its participants the **team leaders of choice** in whatever organizations they may be part of.

Integrated Approach to Leadership Development: The PAR Process

The course develops these leadership capacities through the PAR process, an ongoing cycle organized around three interconnected steps:

PREPARE: *Gain perspectives on yourself through 1:1 coaching and the x360 Leadership Survey, while developing a shared language and understanding in the classroom for naming and framing areas of growth.* Class sessions introduce frameworks and tools to help you recognize patterns, surface assumptions, and work across differences more constructively.

ACT: *Use this information to catalyze growth by translating shared classroom learning and 1:1 coaching insights into practice, including micro-behavioral experiments with peer accountability partners.* The Leadership POD (Peer-Oriented Development group) serves as a nonjudgmental home base for designing, testing, and discussing experiments with the support of an executive leadership coach and peers. Action also includes practical intensive workshops targeting specific challenges you identify with your coach as priorities for further growth, from difficult conversations to leadership presence.

REFLECT: *Supported by 1:1 sessions with an executive leadership coach, process individual experimentation constructively and distill key learning.* This reflection motivates the next PAR cycle.

The PAR cycle methodology is core to leadership development because it helps constructively surface and evolve the assumptions, beliefs, and values that inform leadership capacity and, therefore, the quality of leadership as it is enacted in practice.

About the Use of Executive Leadership Coaches and PODs

Active engagement with both an MIT Leadership Center Executive Coach and your Leadership POD is integral to the PAR process and to deriving meaningful developmental value from the summer experience. Your assigned coach will facilitate the POD.

Your executive coach will support your individual development by helping you interpret feedback, clarify goals, reflect on behavioral patterns, and translate insight into practice. Coaching plays a critical role in converting classroom learning into usable leadership skills.

At the outset of the course, you will be assigned to a Leadership POD, or Peer-Oriented Development group. The POD is designed to support peer reflection, growth, accountability, and experimentation in relation to your leadership goals. It also serves as a laboratory for examining ineffective teaming behaviors and testing more effective ones. Many students find their POD highly valuable and continue to meet long after the course ends.

Before meeting with your executive coach or POD members, you will have the opportunity to complete an x360 assessment to identify behavioral tendencies and gather feedback on your leadership capabilities.

How the Course Is Organized

This course is designed as an integrated developmental experience that unfolds across the summer through five interconnected learning formats:

1. Plenary sessions
2. Leadership PODs
3. 1:1 coaching
4. Practical Intensives
5. Individual experimentation and practice

Each format serves a distinct role while remaining part of a single, mutually reinforcing course experience.

Plenary (classroom) sessions are interspersed throughout the summer. Leadership PODs meet both during plenary session days and between them. Students also participate in 1:1 Coaching and Practical Intensives, while ongoing experimentation with new behaviors and practices in day-to-day work with others serves as a central thread throughout the course.

Getting the Most from the Summer Learning Experience

The MIT Sloan Fellows MBA summer is intense and, by design, cannot be navigated alone. Success requires working productively with teammates, and you will be part of multiple teams this summer and throughout the remainder of your time at MIT Sloan. This can and should be challenging, particularly in a cohort of highly talented, driven individuals with diverse backgrounds and experiences. Misalignments are inevitable. Learning to work through and leverage these conflicts productively can make the summer one of the most formative and positive experiences in your development as a leader. Without that effort, it can feel very long.

Course Credit and Grading

This course revolves around your engagement, contributions, reflections, and willingness to experiment with new, potentially uncomfortable, behaviors. Your grade will be based on a mixture of individual and group deliverables. The course carries **6 credits**. Final grades will be assigned as **letter grades** (A, B, C, etc.). To ensure fairness and consistency, the instructor may apply a curve at their discretion.

All **late assignments** will automatically be downgraded by one point per day until received. See Canvas for assignment and grading details.

All **absences**, whether excused or unexcused, will require completion of a makeup assignment.

Assignments	Due	% of Final Grade	Grading
Attendance and Participation refer to preparation, engagement, and attendance, in plenaries, Leadership PODs, and individual 1:1 coaching. <i>Please note that given the experiential nature of the course, attendance is required unless you have received prior authorization to miss the class. See makeup policies below.</i>	Ongoing	20%	A, B, C,
Study Group Charter at Launch	June 12	5%	P/F
Reflection Paper #1	July 12	20%	A, B, C,
Study Group Charter at Reset	July 16	5%	P/F
Growth Plan Draft 1	July 20	10%	Pass/Redo
Two Practical Intensives	June 24 to August 12	10% (5% each)	P/F
Reflection Paper #2	August 16	20%	A,B,C,
Growth Plan Draft 2	August 24	10%	P/F

Plenary Session Attendance

Students are expected to attend all scheduled plenary sessions, arrive on time, remain present except during designated breaks, and come prepared to engage fully with the material and with peers. Participation includes contributing to full-class and small-group discussions, engaging thoughtfully with readings and assignments, offering feedback to classmates, and demonstrating critical reflection.

The class meets in plenary sessions on six days; see the Course Schedule section within for details. Missing a plenary session, even if a recording is reviewed later, means missing important opportunities for learning and participation.

Excused absences are granted for religious observances and family or health emergencies. Whenever possible, students are expected to notify the TA before the start of the class. Unexcused absences may negatively affect the course grade and will require make-up work. Make-up assignments will include a two-page, written essay and will be assigned by the TA.

Students are expected to report attendance electronically in Canvas during class. Sharing attendance codes with students who are not present, or entering a code when not in class, is a violation of academic integrity and may result in disciplinary consequences, including a failing grade.

Leadership POD Attendance

The same attendance and participation expectations apply to Leadership POD meetings. Because PODs depend on continuity, trust, and peer accountability, students are expected to attend all scheduled POD meetings, arrive on time, participate actively, and communicate any excused absence to the assigned coach before the meeting whenever possible.

Students who are unable to attend a session are responsible for reviewing missed material, staying current with assignments, and coordinating with group members as needed.

Unexcused absences may negatively affect the course grade and will require make-up work. Make-up work will be assigned by the TA.

Additional course requirements information:

- **Practical Intensives:** Attend two sessions.
- **Leadership POD Meetings:** Participate in seven meetings.
- **1:1 Coaching Sessions:** Participate in two sessions.
- **Assignments:** Complete all assignments and make-up assignments.

MIT Sloan Classroom Policies and Norms

MIT Sloan has established a set of policies and norms for students and faculty in the classroom. All students are expected to understand and adhere to the policies outlined in [MIT Sloan Classroom Policies and Norms](#). This document highlights the school's mission and values and explains policies on classroom behavior, academic honesty, and personal conduct.

We expect you to abide by the [MIT Values](#). As part of the course experience, we will work together to create a set of norms to guide conduct in class. In addition, due to the nature of this class, we trust and expect that each of you will respect the confidentiality of any conversations, stories, and experiences shared in our class. This allows us to build a psychologically safe learning community.

Using AI Tools in This Course

Course Policy on Using Generative AI

Machine learning (ML) and artificial intelligence (AI) represent a set of tools (e.g., ChatGPT) that can be used in conjunction with humans to enhance outcomes and impact. For teams, ML and AI represent another way to ensure that the sum is greater than the parts. The true power of ML/AI for individual and team development is yet to be determined, and we encourage you to experiment with them in your efforts to build high performing teams.

You must acknowledge and document your use of ML/AI for any work submitted in this class.

AI Use Course Exception: AI/ML tools may **NOT** be used for the Growth Plan or Reflection Papers. The purpose of these efforts is to get you to think carefully about your own experience, psychological make-up, and plans for growth. These efforts cannot be outsourced. You are, of course, welcome to use tools for catching grammar and typos, but the substance of your submission should be entirely your own. **If you do use AI/ML for these assignments, please describe such usage at the end of your essay.**

Academic Accommodations

If you need an academic accommodation to access this course, please communicate with the instructors of this course as soon as possible. If you have already been approved for an accommodation by [Disability and Access Services](#), please contact your program office so we can implement your approved accommodation. If you have not yet been approved for an accommodation, please contact Disability and Access Services at das-student@mit.edu or 617-253-1674.

Course Schedule

Course Pre-Work – Due June 7, 2026, at 11:59pm (unless otherwise noted in Canvas)

Prep for class – See Canvas for Details

- View two Asynchronous Learning Modules
 - Introduction to Executive Leadership Coaching video
 - “4-CAPS+ Leadership Framework” module
- Complete Course Pre-Reading
 - Argyris, C. (1991). Teaching smart people how to learn. *Harvard Business Review*, May-June.
 - Coutu, D. (2009). Why teams don’t work. *Harvard Business Review*, May-June.
 - Meyer, E. (2014). Navigating the cultural minefield. *Harvard Business Review*, May.
 - Fernandes, M. (2022). How early life experiences shape the leader you become. *Mintlounge*, September.

Assignments – See Canvas for Details

- Complete x360 Leadership Survey and Explore Your Results
- Complete Coaching Agreement
- Complete Part 1, 15.338 Leadership and Teams Lab Baseline Survey
- Complete Part 1, Ignis AI Skills Progress Activity (Optional)

Week 1: June 8 – 14

Monday, June 8

Plenary Sessions

8:30am - 10:00am: Welcome, Introduction, and Course Overview

10:15am - 11:30am: Growth Mindset and Personalization

11:30am - 1:00pm: Lunch Break

1:00pm - 2:30pm: Psychological Safety

Leadership PODs

2:45pm – 4:15pm:

- (Section A) Leadership POD Meeting #1: Creating Psychological Safety
- (Section B) Free Time

4:30pm – 6:00pm:

- (Section A) Free Time
- (Section B) Leadership POD Meeting #1: Creating Psychological Safety

Tuesday, June 9

Plenary Sessions

8:30am - 9:30am: Understanding Emotions

9:45am - 11:30am: Guest Speaker

11:30am - 1:00pm: Lunch Break

1:00pm - 2:30pm: Adult Psychological Development and Emotional Regulation

Leadership PODs

2:45pm – 4:15pm:

- (Section A) Free Time
- (Section B) Leadership POD Meeting #2: Share Your Story

4:30pm – 6:00pm:

- (Section A) Leadership POD Meeting #2: Share Your Story
- (Section B) Free Time

Assignments – See Canvas for Details

- Watch “Perspective Taking and Perspective Getting” Video - Due June 9 at 11:59pm.

Wednesday, June 10

Plenary Sessions

8:30am - 9:30am: Guest Speaker

9:45am - 11:30am: Cross Cultural Awareness

11:30am - 1:00pm: Lunch Break

1:00pm - 2:30pm: Giving and Receiving Effective Feedback

Leadership PODs and Study Groups

2:45pm – 4:15pm:

- (Section A) Leadership POD Meeting #3: Expressive and Reserved Patterns of Behavior
- (Section B) Team Chartering with Study Group

4:30pm – 6:00pm:

- (Section A) Team Chartering with Study Group
- (Section B) Leadership POD Meeting #3: Expressive and Reserved Patterns of Behavior

Assignments – See Canvas for Details

- Create and Submit Study Group Charter - Due June 12 at 11:59pm.
- Create and Submit Leadership POD Introduction Video - Due June 14 at 11:59pm.

Week 2: June 15 – 21

Coaching

- Individual Coaching Session #1 - Complete session between June 11 – June 30.

Week 3: June 22 – 28

Coaching

- If you did not complete your first coaching session last week, please complete it this week.

Leadership PODs

- Leadership POD Meeting #4: Four Player Team Model - Complete meeting by July 2.

Practical Intensives

- Practical Intensives are offered this week. You are required to participate in two practical intensive sessions during the summer.

Week 4: June 29 – July 5

Leadership PODs

- If you did not complete Leadership POD Meeting #4 last week, please complete it by June 30.

Week 5: July 6 – 12

Practical Intensives – See Canvas for Details

- Practical Intensives are offered this week. You are required to participate in two practical intensive sessions during the summer.

Assignments – See Canvas for Details

- Submit Reflection Paper #1 – Due July 12 at 11:59pm.

Week 6: July 13 – 19

Wednesday, July 15

Plenary Sessions

9:00am - 10:30am: Team Basics

10:45am - 12:00pm: Surfacing and Resolving Team Conflict

12:00pm - 1:00pm: Lunch Break

Leadership PODs

1:00pm – 2:30pm:

- (Section A) Free Time
- (Section B) Leadership POD Meeting #5: Managing Conflict and Misalignment

2:45pm – 4:15pm

- (Section A) Leadership POD Meeting #5: Managing Conflict and Misalignment
- (Section B) Free Time

Thursday, July 16

Plenary Sessions

8:30am - 10:00am: Leveraging Diversity in Teams

10:00am - 10:15am: Break

10:15am - 11:30am: Guest Speaker

11:30am - 1:30pm: Study Group Reset Opportunity: Revisit Team Charter

Assignments – See Canvas for Details

- Submit Revised Study Group Charter – Due July 16 at 1:30pm.
- Submit Growth Plan (draft 1) – Due July 20 at 11:59pm.

Week 7: July 20 – 26

Coaching

- Individual Coaching Session #2 - Complete by August 14.

Practical Intensives

- Practical Intensives are offered this week. You are required to participate in two practical intensive sessions during the summer.

Week 8: July 27 – August 2

Coaching

- If you did not complete your second coaching session last week, please schedule it for completion by August 14.

Week 9: August 3 – 9

Leadership PODs

- Leadership POD Meeting #6: Synthesizing Learnings and Feedback - Complete meeting by August 7.

Week 10: August 10 – 16

Practical Intensives

- Practical Intensives are offered this week. You are required to participate in two practical intensive sessions during the summer.

Coaching

- Second individual coaching session should be completed by August 14.

Week 11: August 17 – 23

Wednesday, August 19

Leadership PODs and Plenary Session

1:00pm – 2:15pm:

- (Section A) Recipe Book Creation and Gallery Walk
- (Section B) Leadership POD Meeting #7: Leader of Choice

2:15pm – 2:30pm: Break

2:30pm – 3:45pm

- (Section A) Leadership POD Meeting #7: Leader of Choice
- (Section B) Recipe Book Creation and Gallery Walk

3:45 – 4:30pm: Keynote Speaker Close

Assignments – See Canvas for Details

- Submit Reflection Paper #2 - Due August 23 at 11:59pm.
- Submit Growth Plan (draft 2) – Due August 24 at 11:59pm.